

Rejoice, of Course!

Philippians 4:4-7

Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice! Let your gentleness be evident to all. The Lord is near. Do not be anxious about anything, but in every situation, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God. And the peace of God, which transcends all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Paul was in prison. Important people in the city got upset with him, so they beat him and threw him in jail. What do you think he did there?

He could have cried. It wasn't a nice place to be. He could have complained. He was trying to tell people about Jesus, and they beat him up because of it. What did he do?

He sang! Because Paul wasn't alone there in prison. As he sat in prison, locked up with chains, he sang hymns to God. In other words, while he was in prison, he rejoiced!

When Paul wrote his letter to the Philippians, he was in jail again. He didn't know if he was going to die there or not. The people to whom he was writing didn't have it great either; their church was having some problems with grumbling and arguments.

So, what did Paul tell them to do? He told them to rejoice, of course! "Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice! Let your gentleness be evident to all. The Lord is near."

You probably aren't in prison today, but that doesn't mean everything is going perfectly for you. Life is difficult! You may be having problems with arguing and grumbling with friends or family members. You might be worried about big projects coming up or about all your Christmas plans. So, what does Paul tell you to do?

Rejoice! He says it twice. "I will say it again: Rejoice!" Not because life is perfect or easy. He says rejoice for the same reason he could sing while in prison—because "The Lord is near."

As you get closer to Christmas, sometimes you get closer to a fun visit. Either you're going to visit someone, or they're coming to you. Despite all the stress, you're excited because "Grandma and Grandpa will be here tomorrow!"

That's what life is like with Jesus. He's the best visitor, who brings "peace on earth, good will toward men." He's near! Not only is he coming soon to bring you to heaven, but he is as near to you as the words of the Bible you're reading today or the truths about Jesus that you sing.

So, what should you do today, no matter what's going on in your life? Rejoice, of course! Because no matter what's going on, the Lord is near.

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- What did Paul do while he was in prison?
- What did Paul remind the people of Philippi to do despite their problems?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- Why can we rejoice even when life isn't perfect?
- What are some Christmas hymns that help you rejoice?

Questions for Middle School and Above

- Explain what it means when Paul says, "the Lord is near"?
- Pick a favorite, joyful Christmas hymn. Sing or hum it as you go through your day.

Closing Prayer:

"Rejoice! Rejoice! Emmanuel shall come to you, O Israel!" Amen.